the crowds surrounding us). So a couple of us gently began to prod him to start engaging with individuals. Pointing out families in distant balconies, we got him to catch their attention and wave at each one of them. We steered him to converse with families waiting for us on the pavements. And we literally pulled him to join us in seeking the blessings of some village elders sitting at the edge of their doorposts. We soon saw a gradual transformation as he began to realize how simple it was. And so he began to awkwardly engage with everyone, up to the point where he wouldn't leave a place until he had shaken every hand! His newfound confidence also had hilarious consequences, like when he excitedly waved to some children who were with their mothers, shouting, 'Hi babies!' Since it wasn't clear who the intended recipients of his salutation were, it solicited stunned silences (and some nasty glares) from all the ladies and general hilarity from everyone else.

Many such instances made us confront our own prejudices about politics and politicians. Ironically, we ourselves unconsciously buy into the pervasive belief that people gravitate towards politics for upward economic and social mobility, as well as shortcuts to hack life's struggles. It is true that these are eternal temptations. But in my limited experience, those in public service are primarily driven by wanting to do something purposeful —for our people, the nation and indeed humanity at large. In fact, many of the yatris were from limited means and couldn't afford to go back to their homes when the Yatra stopped for a week. But because the process of staying true to one's path involves sacrificing social constructs of the normal, politics is deeply isolating. Facing overwhelming odds, there is no one to help us navigate the maze that is politics. This is exacerbated by the fact that political organizations (like all systems) have an inbuilt inertia to them. Like mindless bots, we are stuck in a routine that robs us of our agency and creativity. And once someone hacks that system successfully, most consciously choose to maintain the status quo. Those conferred with these new-age janeus (sacred threads that mark certain castes) either include unfavourably or exclude outrightly (depending on proximity to them and conformity to their rules). Inexplicably, such people believe that we deserve